



“The Growth of the City: An Introduction to a Research Project”

from Robert Park, Ernest W. Burgess,
and Roderick D. McKenzie, *The City* (1925)

Ernest W. Burgess

EDITORS' INTRODUCTION



Ernest W. Burgess was a member of the famed sociology department at the University of Chicago in the 1920s and 1930s that set out to reinvent modern sociology by taking academic research to the streets and by using the city of Chicago itself as a “living laboratory” for the study of urban problems and social dynamics.

Throughout a long and productive career, Burgess addressed a whole series of issues that connected the social dynamics of the city with the lives of its citizens. He wrote extensively on issues related to marriage and the family, the relation of personality to social groups, and, in the final decades of his life, problems of the elderly. His most famous contribution to the study of the city was the 1925 essay reprinted here: “The Growth of the City.”

Burgess's seminal analysis of the interrelation of the social growth and the physical expansion of modern cities helped foster the subfield of urban geography as well as urban sociology. Burgess focused on patterns within a single city (the internal structure of the city), rather than relationships among cities (systems of cities).

In the expansion of the city, Burgess wrote, a process of distribution takes place, which sifts and sorts and relocates individuals and groups by residence and occupation. It was this dynamic process – “process” was one of Burgess's favorite words – that gives form and character to the city.

Chicago, at the time this selection was written, was a dynamic, rapidly growing city of recent immigrants. Chicago's wealth was built on its location as the receiving center for natural resources from the developing American frontier. Rail lines from the parts of the United States that developed in the latter half of the nineteenth and first part of the twentieth century converged in Chicago and then continued to the older, more populous cities in the east. Grain from the west, lumber from the north, and cattle from the southwest all came into Chicago to be sorted, processed, and shipped east. Miles of grain elevators, enormous lumberyards, and huge slaughterhouses were able to employ hundreds of thousands of unskilled immigrant workers. Traders, factory owners, and entrepreneurs grew rich. First- and second-generation immigrants who had prospered in the booming economy formed a middle class.

Central to Burgess's analysis of urban growth was his famous model based on a series of concentric circles that divided the city into five zones. The concentric zone model looks like a static map of Chicago's economic demography (a cross-sectional analysis), but the model was also a theoretical diagram of a dynamic process illustrating how urban social and economic structure changes over time (a longitudinal analysis). Burgess called the process of neighborhood change “succession,” a term he borrowed from the science of plant ecology. By borrowing terminology from the natural sciences, and by drawing analogies between the urban and the natural worlds, Burgess helped establish the study of social ecology as a distinct approach to understanding the underlying patterns of urban growth and development.

For all the problems and pathologies of urban life, Burgess saw cities as progressing. Within a generation, Chicago had morphed from a frontier town to a booming world metropolis. His model is systematic and rational.

He was convinced that there was an underlying logic to the social and economic structure of cities that could be understood scientifically. He saw the city itself as the driving force behind the region of which it was a part. While Chicago was a world city at the time, he believed Chicago's growth patterns were primarily endogenous – governed by local, rather than global, forces.

Following the publication of Burgess's essay, a number of urban theorists offered modifications and refutations of the simple elegance of the concentric zone model. In 1939, real estate economist Homer Hoyt proposed a sectoral model for modern capitalist cities based on wedges of activity extending outward from the city center along transportation corridors. In 1945, geographers Chauncy Harris and Edward Ullman suggested a multiple nuclei model, arguing that cities developed around several centers of economic activity, not just one.

The Burgess model remains essential reading in urban geography and urban sociology courses and is still recognized as a brilliant and provocative piece of theoretical writing. Both Burgess's applied fieldwork methods and his concentric zone model continue to inspire modern scholars and influence important works on urban space. Elijah Anderson (p. 131) received his PhD in Sociology from the University of Chicago. Ali Madanipour's analysis of social exclusion and space (p. 203) owes a profound debt to Burgess.

The Burgess model has also been widely criticized. Michael Dear (p. 187) and many other modern writers either reject the Burgess model altogether or argue that if it accurately described urban processes in mid-twentieth century cities, it no longer does today. Burgess's model is in the modernist tradition. It assumed a logical, rational set of processes with the central business district at the center emanating outward in concentric rings to the edge of the city and the suburbs beyond. But does this model adequately describe the process of urban change today? A competing, postmodernist school of thought, the Los Angeles school of urbanism thinks not. The selection in by Michael Dear (p. 187) argues that growth in Los Angeles today is largely determined by development in the periphery of the region, not what happens in the CBD as Burgess argued. Global structural forces, Dear and other LA school theorists argue, determine metropolitan spatial structure, not decisions made by individuals acting as free agents as Burgess believed.

In criticizing Burgess for his lack of attention to gender issues, Daphne Spain (p. 193) and other writers question the premises of social ecology in which some social groups (Blacks, immigrants, women) are relegated to inferior status by deterministic forces beyond their control. She and other activist scholars argue that changes in consciousness and political action can change deterministic processes.

Computer technology, including statistical packages and Geographic Information Systems (GIS) software, now makes it possible for present-day geographers and sociologists to summarize vast amounts of data and map the internal structure of cities in ever more sophisticated ways. Thus, understanding of the relationship between social groups and urban form pioneered by Burgess continues to advance by leaps and bounds.

Ernest W. Burgess (1886–1966) was a professor of sociology at the University of Chicago and one of the most influential members of the Chicago School of sociology that included such luminaries as his officemate Louis Wirth, author of "Urbanism as a Way of Life" (p. 115), and Robert E. Park who developed important sociological theory about immigration, assimilation, and social ecology. Burgess served as chair of the University of Chicago sociology department and as president of the American Sociological Society (1934), Sociological Research Association (1942), and the Social Science Research Council (1945–1946). He was the editor of the *American Journal of Sociology* from 1936 to 1940.

This selection is taken from Robert E. Park, Ernest W. Burgess, and Roderick D. McKenzie, *The City* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1984) – originally published in 1925.

Burgess's most important writings are reprinted in Donald J. Bogue (ed.), *Basic Writings of Ernest W. Burgess* (Chicago: Community and Family Study Center, University of Chicago, 1974). The University of Chicago maintains Burgess's papers in its Special Collections Research Center.

Nicholas Fyfe and Elizabeth Kenny's *Urban Geography Reader* (London and New York: Routledge, 2005) in the Routledge Urban Reader Series contains writings by the other most important twentieth-century theorists of the internal structure of the city: Homer Hoyt on his sector model and Chauncy Harris and Edward Ullman on their multiple nuclei theory of the internal structure of cities.

The outstanding fact of modern society is the growth of great cities. Nowhere else have the enormous changes which the machine industry has made in our social life registered themselves with such obviousness as in the cities. In the United States the transition from a rural to an urban civilization, though beginning later than in Europe, has taken place, if not more rapidly and completely, at any rate more logically in its most characteristic forms.

All the manifestations of modern life which are peculiarly urban – the skyscraper, the subway, the department store, the daily newspaper, and social work – are characteristically American. The more subtle changes in our social life, which in their cruder manifestations are termed “social problems,” problems that alarm and bewilder us, such as divorce, delinquency, and social unrest, are to be found in their most acute forms in our largest American cities. The profound and “subversive” forces which have wrought these changes are measured in the physical growth and expansion of cities. That is the significance of the comparative statistics of Weber, Bucher, and other students.

These statistical studies, although dealing mainly with the effects of urban growth, brought out into clear relief certain distinctive characteristics of urban as compared with rural populations. The larger proportion of women to men in the cities than in the open country, the greater percentage of youth and middle-aged, the higher ratio of the foreign-born, the increased heterogeneity of occupation increase with the growth of the city and profoundly alter its social structure. These variations in the composition of population are indicative of all the changes going on in the social organization of the community. In fact, these changes are a part of the growth of the city and suggest the nature of the processes of growth.

The only aspect of growth adequately described by Bucher and Weber was the rather obvious process of the aggregation of urban population. Almost as overt a process, that of expansion, has been investigated from a different and very practical point of view by groups interested in city planning, zoning, and regional surveys. Even more significant than the increasing density of urban population is its correlative tendency to overflow, and so to extend over wider

areas, and to incorporate these areas into a larger communal life. This paper, therefore, will treat first of the expansion of the city, and then of the less-known processes of urban metabolism and mobility which are closely related to expansion.

EXPANSION AS PHYSICAL GROWTH

The expansion of the city from the standpoint of the city plan, zoning, and regional surveys is thought of almost wholly in terms of its physical growth. Traction studies have dealt with the development of transportation in its relation to the distribution of population throughout the city. The surveys made by the Bell Telephone Company and other public utilities have attempted to forecast the direction and the rate of growth of the city in order to anticipate the future demands for the extension of their services. In the city plan the location of parks and boulevards, the widening of traffic streets, the provision for a civic center, are all in the interest of the future control of the physical development of the city.

This expansion in area of our largest cities is now being brought forcibly to our attention by the Plan for the Study of New York and Its Environs, and by the formation of the Chicago Regional Planning Association, which extends the metropolitan district of the city to a radius of 50 miles, embracing 4,000 square miles of territory. ~~Both are attempting to measure expansion in order to deal with the changes that accompany city growth. In England, where more than one-half of the inhabitants live in cities having a population of 100,000 and over, the lively appreciation of the bearing of urban expansion on social organization is thus expressed by C.B. Fawcett:~~

One of the most important and striking developments in the growth of the urban populations of the more advanced peoples of the world during the last few decades has been the appearance of a number of vast urban aggregates, or conurbations, far larger and more numerous than the great cities of any preceding age. These have usually been formed by the simultaneous expansion of a number of neighboring towns, which have grown out toward each other until

they have reached a practical coalescence in one continuous urban area. Each such conurbation still has within it many nuclei of denser town growth, most of which represent the central areas of the various towns from which it has grown, and these nuclear patches are connected by the less densely urbanized areas which began as suburbs of these towns. The latter are still usually rather less continuously occupied by buildings, and often have many open spaces.

These great aggregates of town dwellers are a new feature in the distribution of man over the earth. At the present day there are from thirty to forty of them, each containing more than a million people, whereas only a hundred years ago there were, outside the great centers of population on the waterways of China, not more than two or three. Such aggregations of people are phenomena of great geographical and social importance; they give rise to new problems in the organization of the life and well-being of their inhabitants and in their varied activities. Few of them have yet developed a social consciousness at all proportionate to their magnitude, or fully realized themselves as definite groupings of people with many common interests, emotions and thoughts.

In Europe and America the tendency of the great city to expand has been recognized in the term "the metropolitan area of the city," which far overruns its political limits, and, in the case of New York and Chicago, even state lines. The metropolitan area may be taken to include urban territory that is physically contiguous, but it is coming to be defined by that facility of transportation that enables a business man to live in a suburb of Chicago and to work in the loop, and his wife to shop at Marshall Field's and attend grand opera in the Auditorium.

EXPANSION AS A PROCESS

No study of expansion as a process has yet been made, although the materials for such a study and intimations of different aspects of the process are contained in city planning, zoning, and regional surveys. The typical processes of the expansion of the city can best be illustrated, perhaps, by a series of concentric circles, which may be numbered to designate both the successive zones of urban extension and the types of areas differentiated in the process of expansion [Figure 1].

[Figure 1] represents an ideal construction of the tendencies of any town or city to expand radially from its central business district – on the map "the Loop" (I). Encircling the downtown area there is normally an area in transition, which is being invaded by business and light manufacture (II). A third area (III) is inhabited by the workers in industries who have escaped from the area of deterioration (II) but who desire to live within easy access of their work. Beyond this zone is the "residential area" (IV) of high-class apartment buildings or of exclusive "restricted" districts of single family dwellings. Still farther, out beyond the city limits, is the commuters' zone: suburban areas, or satellite cities, within a thirty- to sixty-minute ride of the central business district.

This [figure] brings out clearly the main fact of expansion, namely, the tendency of each inner zone to extend its area by the invasion of the next outer zone. This aspect of expansion may be called *succession*, a process which has been studied in detail in plant ecology. If this [figure] is applied to Chicago, all four of these zones were in its early history included in the circumference of the inner zone, the present business district. The present boundaries of the area of deterioration were not many years ago those of the zone now inhabited by independent wage-earners, and within the memories of thousands of Chicagoans contained the residences of the "best families." It hardly needs to be added that neither Chicago nor any other city fits perfectly into this ideal scheme. Complications are introduced by the lake front, the Chicago River, railroad lines, historical factors in the location of industry, the relative degree of the resistance of communities to invasion, etc.

Besides extension and succession, the general process of expansion in urban growth involves the antagonistic and yet complementary processes of concentration and decentralization. In all cities there is the natural tendency for local and outside transportation to converge in the central business district. In the downtown section of every large city we expect to find the department stores, the skyscraper office buildings, the railroad stations, the great hotels, the theaters, the art museum, and the city hall. Quite naturally, almost inevitably, the economic, cultural, and political life centers here. The relation of centralization to the other processes of city life may be roughly gauged by the fact that over half a million people daily enter and leave Chicago's "loop." More recently sub-business centers have grown up in

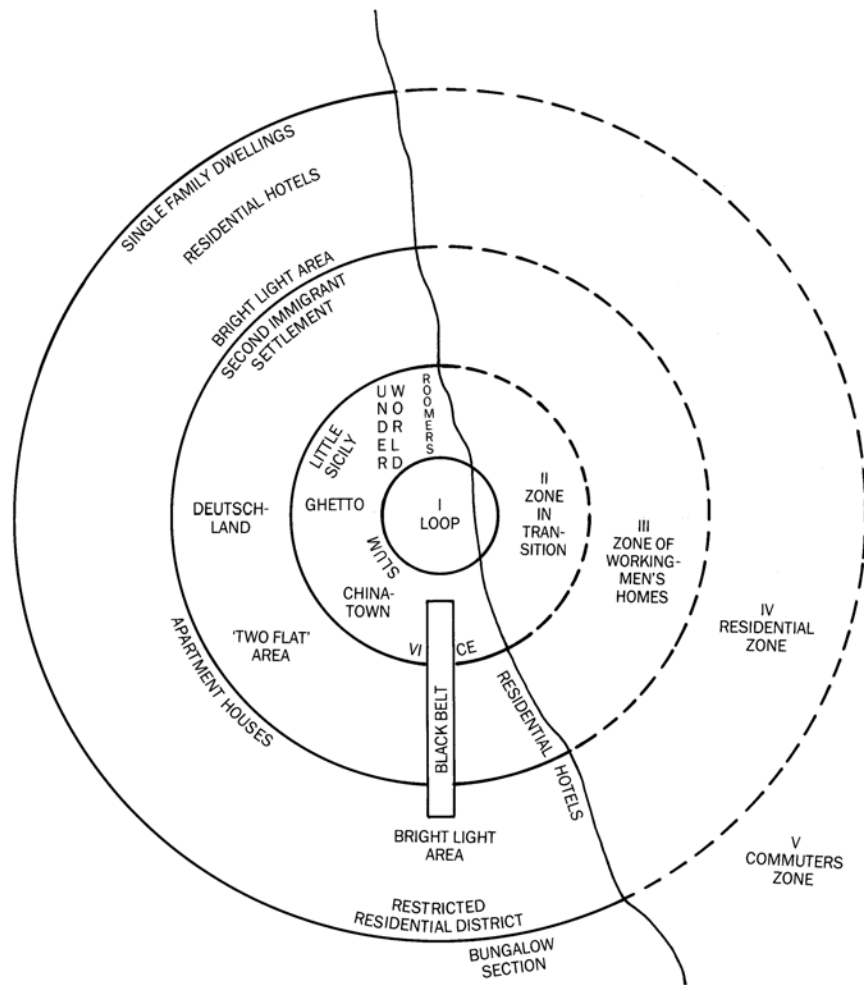


Figure 1

outlying zones. These "satellite loops" do not, it seems, represent the "hoped for" revival of the neighborhood, but rather a telescoping of several local communities into a larger economic unity. The Chicago of yesterday, an agglomeration of country towns and immigrant colonies, is under-going a process of re-organization into a centralized decentralized system of local communities coalescing into sub-business areas visibly or invisibly dominated by the central business district. The actual processes of what may be called centralized decentralization are now being studied in the development of the chain store, which is only one illustration of the change in the basis of the urban organization.

Expansion, as we have seen, deals with the physical growth of the city, and with the extension of the

technical services that have made city life not only livable, but comfortable, even luxurious. Certain of these basic necessities of urban life are possible only through tremendous development of communal existence. Three millions of people in Chicago are dependent upon one unified water system, one giant gas company, and one huge electric light plant. Yet, like most of the other aspects of our communal urban life, this economic co-operation is an example of co-operation without a shred of what the "spirit of co-operation" is commonly thought to signify. The great public utilities are a part of the mechanization of life in great cities, and have little or no other meaning for social organization.

Yet the processes of expansion, and especially the rate of expansion, may be studied not only in the

physical growth and business development, but also in the consequent changes in the social organization and in personality types. How far is the growth of the city, in its physical and technical aspects, matched by a natural but adequate readjustment in the social organization? What, for a city, is a normal rate of expansion, a rate of expansion with which controlled changes in the social organization might successfully keep pace?

SOCIAL ORGANIZATION AND DISORGANIZATION AS PROCESSES OF METABOLISM

These questions may best be answered, perhaps, by thinking of urban growth as a resultant of organization and disorganization analogous to the anabolic and katabolic processes of metabolism in the body. In what way are individuals incorporated into the life of a city? By what process does a person become an organic part of his society? The natural process of acquiring culture is by birth. A person is born into a family already adjusted to a social environment – in this case the modern city. The natural rate of increase of population most favorable for assimilation may then be taken as the excess of the birth-rate over the death-rate, but is this the normal rate of city growth? Certainly, modern cities have increased and are increasing in population at a far higher rate. However, the natural rate of growth may be used to measure the disturbances of metabolism caused by any excessive increase, as those which followed the great influx of southern Negroes into northern cities since the war. In a similar way all cities show deviations in composition by age and sex from a standard population such as that of Sweden, unaffected in recent years by any great emigration or immigration. Here again, marked variations, as any great excess of males over females, or of females over males, or in the proportion of children, or of grown men or women, are symptomatic of abnormalities in social metabolism.

Normally the processes of disorganization and organization may be thought of as in reciprocal relationship to each other, and as co-operating in a moving equilibrium of social order toward an end vaguely or definitely regarded as progressive. So far as disorganization points to reorganization and makes for more efficient adjustment, disorganization must be conceived not as pathological, but as normal. Disorga-

nization as preliminary to reorganization of attitudes and conduct is almost invariably the lot of the new-comer to the city, and the discarding of the habitual, and often of what has been to him the moral, is not infrequently accompanied by sharp mental conflict and sense of personal loss. Oftener, perhaps, the change gives sooner or later a feeling of emancipation and an urge toward new goals.

In the expansion of the city a process of distribution takes place which sifts and sorts and relocates individuals and groups by residence and occupation. The resulting differentiation of the cosmopolitan American city into areas is typically all from one pattern, with only interesting minor modifications. Within the central business district or on an adjoining street is the "main stem" of "hobohemia," the teeming Rialto of the homeless migratory man of the Middle West. In the zone of deterioration encircling the central business section are always to be found the so-called "slums" and "bad lands," with their submerged regions of poverty, degradation, and disease, and their underworlds of crime and vice. Within a deteriorating area are rooming-house districts, the purgatory of "lost souls." Nearby is the Latin Quarter, where creative and rebellious spirits resort. The slums are also crowded to overflowing with immigrant colonies – the Ghetto, Little Sicily, Greek town, Chinatown – fascinatingly combining old world heritages and American adaptations. Wedging out from here is the Black Belt with its free and disorderly life. The area of deterioration, while essentially one of decay, of stationary or declining population, is also one of regeneration, as witness the mission, the settlement, the artists' colony, radical centers – all obsessed with the vision of a new and better world.

The next zone is also inhabited predominantly by factory and shop workers, but skilled and thrifty. This is an area of second immigrant settlement, generally of the second generation. It is the region of escape from the slum, the *Deutschland* of the aspiring Ghetto family. For *Deutschland* (literally "Germany") is the name given, half in envy, half in derision, to that region beyond the Ghetto where successful neighbors appear to be imitating German Jewish standards of living. But the inhabitant of this area in turn looks to the "Promised Land" beyond, to its residential hotels, its apartment-house region, its "satellite loops," and its "bright light" areas.

This differentiation into natural economic and cultural groupings gives form and character to the city.

For segregation offers the group, and thereby the individuals who compose the group, a place and a role in the total organization of city life. Segregation limits development in certain directions, but releases it in others. These areas tend to accentuate certain traits, to attract and develop their kind of individuals, and so to become further differentiated.

The division of labor in the city likewise illustrates disorganization, reorganization and increasing differentiation. The immigrant from rural communities in Europe and America seldom brings with him economic skill of any great value in our industrial, commercial, or professional life. Yet interesting occupational selection has taken place by nationality, explainable more by racial temperament or circumstance than by old-world economic background as Irish policemen, Greek ice-cream parlors, Chinese laundries, Negro porters, Belgian janitors, etc.

The facts that in Chicago one million (996,589) individuals gainfully employed reported 509 occupations, and that over 1,000 men and women in *Who's Who* gave 116 different vocations give some notion of how in the city the minute differentiation of occupation "analyzes and sifts the population, separating and classifying the diverse elements." These figures also afford some intimation of the complexity and complication of the modern industrial mechanism and the intricate segregation and isolation of divergent economic groups. Interrelated with this economic division of labor is a corresponding division into social classes and into cultural and recreational groups. From this multiplicity of groups, with their different patterns of life, the person finds his congenial social world and – what is not feasible in the narrow confines of a village – may move and live in widely separated, and perchance conflicting, worlds. Personal disorganization may be but the failure to harmonize the canons of conduct of two divergent groups.

If the phenomena of expansion and metabolism indicate that a moderate degree of disorganization may and does facilitate social organization, they indicate as well that rapid urban expansion is accompanied by excessive increases in disease, crime, disorder, vice, insanity and suicide, rough indexes of social disorganization. But what are the indexes of the causes, rather than of the effects, of the disordered social metabolism of the city? The excess of the actual over the natural increase of population has already been suggested as a criterion. The significance of this increase consists in the immigration into a metro-

politan city like New York and Chicago of tens of thousands of persons annually. Their invasion of the city has the effect of a tidal wave inundating first the immigrant colonies, the ports of first entry, dislodging thousands of inhabitants who overflow into the next zone, and so on and on until the momentum of the wave has spent its force on the last urban zone. The whole effect is to speed up expansion, to speed up industry, to speed up the "junking" process in the area of deterioration (II). These internal movements of the population become the more significant for study. What movement is going on in the city, and how may this movement be measured? It is easier, of course, to classify movement within the city than to measure it. There is the movement from residence to residence, change of occupation, labor turnover, movement to and from work, movement for recreation and adventure. This leads to the question: what is the significant aspect of movement for the study of the changes in city life? The answer to this question leads directly to the important distinction between movement and mobility.

MOBILITY AS THE PULSE OF THE COMMUNITY

Movement, per se, is not an evidence of change or of growth. In fact, movement may be a fixed and unchanging order of motion, designed to control a constant situation, as in routine movement. Movement that is significant for growth implies a change of movement in response to a new stimulus or situation. Change of movement of this type is called *mobility*. Movement of the nature of routine finds its typical expression in work. Change of movement, or mobility, is characteristically expressed in adventure. The great city, with its "bright lights," its emporiums of novelties and bargains, its palaces of amusement, its underworld of vice and crime, its risks of life and property from accident, robbery, and homicide, has become the region of the most intense degree of adventure and danger, excitement and thrill.

Mobility, it is evident, involves change, new experience, stimulation. Stimulation induces a response of the person to those objects in his environment which afford expression for his wishes. For the person, as for the physical organism, stimulation is essential to growth. Response to stimulation is wholesome so long as it is a correlated integral reaction of the entire

personality. When the reaction is segmental, that is, detached from, and uncontrolled by, the organization of personality, it tends to become disorganizing or pathological. That is why stimulation for the sake of stimulation, as in the restless pursuit of pleasure, partakes of the nature of vice.

The mobility of city life, with its increase in the number and intensity of stimulations, tends inevitably to confuse and to demoralize the person. For an essential element in the mores and in personal morality is consistency, consistency of the type that is natural in the social control of the primary group. Where mobility is the greatest, and where in consequence primary controls break down completely, as in the zone of deterioration in the modern city, there develop areas of demoralization, of promiscuity, and of vice.

In our studies of the city it is found that areas of mobility are also the regions in which are found juvenile delinquency, boys' gangs, crime, poverty, wife desertion, divorce, abandoned infants, vice.

These concrete situations show why mobility is perhaps the best index of the state of metabolism of the city. Mobility may be thought of, in more than a fanciful sense, as the "pulse of the community." Like the pulse of the human body, it is a process which reflects and is indicative of all the changes that are taking place in the community, and which is susceptible of analysis into elements which may be stated numerically.

The elements entering into mobility may be classified under two main heads: (1) the state of mutability of the person, and (2) the number and kind of contacts or stimulations in his environment. The mutability of city populations varies with sex and age composition, and the degree of detachment of the person from the family and from other groups. All these factors may be expressed numerically. The new stimulations to which a population responds can be measured in terms of change of movement or of increasing contacts. Statistics on the movement of urban population may only measure routine, but an increase at a higher ratio than the increase of population measures mobility. In 1860 the horse-car lines of New York City carried about 50,000,000 passengers; in 1890 the trolley cars (and a few surviving horse-cars) transported about 500,000,000; in 1921, the elevated, subway, surface, and electric and steam suburban lines carried a total of more than 2,500,000,000 passengers. In Chicago the total annual rides per capita on the surface and elevated lines were 164 in 1890; 215 in 1900; 320 in 1910; and 338 in 1921. In addition, the

rides per capita on steam and electric suburban lines almost doubled between 1916 (23) and 1921 (41), and the increasing use of the automobile must not be overlooked. For example, the number of automobiles in Illinois increased from 131,140 in 1915 to 833,920 in 1923.

Mobility may be measured not only by these changes of movement, but also by increase of contacts. While the increase of population of Chicago in 1912-22 was less than 25 percent (23.6 percent), the increase of letters delivered to Chicagoans was double that (49.6 percent) — from 693,048,196 to 1,038,007,854. In 1912 New York had 8.8 telephones; in 1922, 16.9 per 100 inhabitants. Boston had, in 1912, 10.1 telephones; ten years later, 19.5 telephones per 100 inhabitants. In the same decade the figures for Chicago increased from 12.3 to 21.6 per 100 population. But increase of the use of the telephone is probably more significant than increase in the number of telephones. The number of telephone calls in Chicago increased from 606,131,928 in 1914 to 944,010,586 in 1922, an increase of 55.7 percent, while the population increased only 13.4 percent.

Land values, since they reflect movement, afford one of the most sensitive indexes of mobility. The highest land values in Chicago are at the point of greatest mobility in the city, at the corner of State and Madison streets, in the Loop. A traffic count showed that at the rush period 31,000 people an hour, or 210,000 men and women in sixteen and one-half hours, passed the southwest corner. For over ten years land values in the Loop have been stationary but in the same time they have doubled, quadrupled and even sextupled in the strategic corners of the "satellite loops," an accurate index of the changes which have occurred. Our investigations so far seem to indicate that variations in land values, especially where correlated with differences in rents, offer perhaps the best single measure of mobility, and so of all the changes taking place in the expansion and growth of the city.

In general outline, I have attempted to present the point of view and methods of investigation which the department of sociology is employing in its studies in the growth of the city, namely, to describe urban expansion in terms of extension, succession, and concentration; to determine how expansion disturbs metabolism when disorganization is in excess of organization; and, finally, to define mobility and to propose it as a measure both of expansion and meta-

bolism, susceptible to precise quantitative formulation, so that it may be regarded almost literally as the pulse of the community. In a way, this statement might serve as an introduction to any one of five or six research projects under way in the department. The project, however, in which I am directly engaged is an attempt to apply these methods of investigation to a cross-section of the city – to put this area, as it were, under the microscope, and so to study in more detail and with greater control and precision the processes which have been described here in the large. For this purpose the West Side Jewish community has been selected. This community includes the so-called “Ghetto,” or area of first settlement, and Lawndale,

the so-called “Deutschland,” or area of second settlement. This area has certain obvious advantages for this study, from the standpoint of expansion, metabolism, and mobility. It exemplifies the tendency to expansion radially from the business center of the city. It is now relatively a homogeneous cultural group. Lawndale is itself an area in flux, with the tide of migrants still flowing in from the Ghetto and a constant egress to more desirable regions of the residential zone. In this area, too, it is also possible to study how the expected outcome of this high rate of mobility in social and personal disorganization is counteracted in large measure by the efficient communal organization of the Jewish community.

The city reader

Author(s) LeGates, Richard T.; Stout, Frederic

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“The Los Angeles School of Urbanism: An Intellectual History”

Michael Dear

EDITORS' INTRODUCTION



In this provocative essay, University of California Berkeley professor of City and Regional Planning Michael Dear summarizes a radically different model of the logic behind the spatial structure of regions than Ernest Burgess's classical concentric zone model. Dear's model reflects postmodernist thinking – particularly ideas of an important group of Southern California intellectuals identified as the Los Angeles school of urbanism. One good way to think about the internal structure of city-regions is by contrasting the Chicago school model (as described by Burgess) with the LA school model (as described by Dear).

Schools of thought come into being when a group of individuals at some place and time develop a reasonably consistent body of ideas that is different enough from other ideas at the time that it qualifies as something special. Members of the “Dutch school” of painters in the Netherlands in the fifteenth and sixteenth century, for example, worked in a distinct style that set them apart from other artists of the time. Within the Dutch school, Rembrandt's style was different from Johannes Vermeer's, but anyone comparing a painting from the Dutch school would immediately see that it is dramatically different from, for example, a landscape painted by a painter in the nineteenth-century French impressionist school of art. Similarly, the Los Angeles school of urbanism consists of the work of a group of intellectual mavericks with different approaches, but who share enough in common that they self-identify and are identified by others as a distinct school of urbanist thought. Dear correctly argues that their point of view is radically different from earlier modernist points of view, including Burgess's.

The LA school of urbanism includes neo-Marxist geographers, left-wing urban sociologists, postmodernist architectural critics, labor historians and other Southern California intellectuals. Mike Davis, the author of “Fortress L.A.” (p. 212) is a member and coined the term “LA school.” Their methods are qualitative. Members of the LA school are to the left of the American political spectrum. Neo-Marxist members of the LA school generally agree with Engels that urban development is driven by capitalist self-interest, albeit in a contemporary form.

LA school members consider themselves postmodernists. They distinguish their approach to cities from modernists like Le Corbusier (p. 379). In the selection that follows, Dear characterizes the Burgess concentric zone model of the internal structure of the city as in the modernist tradition.

According to Dear, key differences between modernist and postmodernist views as represented by the Burgess and LA school models are that:

- Burgess and other modernists view city-regions as coherent regional systems in which the central business district (CBD) organizes the rest of city space and the metropolitan hinterland beyond the formal city limits. In contrast, postmodernist members of the LA school view city-regions as fragmented, with different areas influenced largely by global, rather than purely local, forces. LA school theorists argue that CBDs no longer act as centers defining the city-region. Rather, they argue that urban peripheries tend to organize what remains of the urban center.

- According to Dear, Burgess believed that the personal choices of individuals shape overall urban conditions. In contrast, Dear and LA theorists believe that great global structural forces determine metropolitan spatial structure. They believe that global corporate-dominated connectivity is balancing or even offsetting individual-centered agency in urban processes.
- Burgess and his Chicago School colleagues held an essentially teleological view of urban evolution. They believed cities were evolving to ever more advanced and modern levels; that, despite their problems, cities were becoming better over time. The LA school questions that assumption. They see the evolution of cities as a nonlinear, chaotic process. They see many pathological aspects of postmodern LA that make it arguable a much less advanced city than many earlier cities. LA school members generally share Mike Davis's dystopianism (p. 212).
- Postmodernist concepts include the world city (a few urban centers controlling the world economy), the dual city (increasingly polarized by race, class, income, and gender), the hybrid city (characterized by new hybrid communities), and cybercity (in which digital connectivity shapes all aspects of urban life).

The most compelling metaphor Dear and his colleague Steven Flusty use to describe the LA school paradigm is "Keno capitalism." Keno is a game of chance in which a square in a rectangular grid is selected randomly by chance. That event triggers activity in squares closest to the selected square. Different random squares on the board may be in play at any time. Squares that are furthest from the selected square(s) have little or activity. Players with "winning" squares, selected by chance, win; players with squares furthest from the selected squares lose the game. Substituting a real-world land parcel for the Keno square, Dear and Flusty argue that in Los Angeles and other of the world's most dynamic metropolitan regions, global development consortia choose a land parcel for development nearly at random and inject a huge amount of capital to develop megaprojects there. Often they might as well have chosen a different parcel. Land values close to the chosen parcel skyrocket and the selection of the parcels touches off a whole string of development activities nearby. Other parcels in the metropolitan region – often in the periphery rather than the city itself – are also being selected, and frantic development activity occurs close to them as well. In between the winning parcels, little development activity occurs, or neighborhoods decline. A metropolitan region experiencing this form of development becomes, in Dear's words, "a noncontiguous collage of parcelized, consumption-oriented landscapes linked only by the (dis)information superhighway." An aerial photograph of such a region would look like a Keno board with apparently random spots of intense development here and there and little activity elsewhere. Dear notes that existing (modernist) forms are not completely irrelevant. Their past influence is discernible in postmodern landscapes and they continue to modestly influence the emerging spaces of postmodernity. Yasser Elshestawy's description of megaprojects for the rich built by Emaar, a real estate development corporation owned by the government of Dubai (p. 328), dropped down in the middle of poor informal settlements in Cairo is an excellent example of Keno capitalism at work.

Dear is an excellent writer and he and other members of the LA school use compelling images to describe what they perceive to be the new reality. Postmodern urbanism as described by the LA school is characterized by edge cities, privatopias, minoritization, theme park environments, fortification, containment centers, and technopoles.

Michael Dear is a professor of City and Regional Planning at the University of California, Berkeley, where he teaches courses on urban theory, the state, social theory, and borderlands. He is an honorary professor at the Bartlett School of Planning, University College London. Dear has degrees in geography, town planning, and regional science. His current research focuses on comparative urbanism and the future of US–Mexico borderlands. Dear's research interests include homelessness, postmodern theory, Los Angeles, comparative urbanism, and the cultural geography of the US–Mexico borderlands. He was a founding editor of the journal *Society and Space: Environment and Planning D*.

Dear's books include *Why Walls Won't Work: Repairing the US-Mexico Divide* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), *From Chicago to LA: Making Sense of Urban Theory* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 2001), *Postborder City: Cultural Spaces of Baja California*, co-authored with Gustavo LeClerk (New York and London: Routledge, 2003), *The Postmodern Urban Condition* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2001), *The Spaces of Postmodernity*, co-authored with Steven Flusty (London and New York: Wiley-Blackwell, 2000), *Rethinking Los*

Angeles (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 1996), and *Landscapes of Despair*, co-authored with Jennifer Wolch (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1992).

Other writings on postmodernist urban theory include Edward W. Soja, *Postmodern Geographies: The Reassertion of Space in Critical Social Theory*, 2nd edn (New York: Verso, 2011), Doreen Massey, *For Space* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 2005), Neil Smith, *Uneven Development: Nature, Capital, and the Production of Space*, 3rd edn (Athens, GA: University of Georgia, 2008), and David Harvey, *Limits to Capital*, updated version (New York: Verso, 2007).

The basic primer of the Chicago School was *The City*. Originally published in 1925, the book retains a tremendous vitality far beyond its interest as a historical document. I regard the book as emblematic of a modernist analytical paradigm that remained popular for most of the 20th century. Its assumptions included:

- a modernist view of the city as a unified whole, i.e., a coherent regional system in which the center organizes its hinterland;
- an individual-centered understanding of the urban condition; urban process in *The City* is typically grounded in the individual subjectivities of urbanites, their personal choices ultimately explaining the overall urban condition, including spatial structure, crime, poverty, and racism; and
- a linear evolutionist paradigm, in which processes lead from tradition to modernity, from primitive to advanced, from community to society, and so on.

There may be other important assumptions of the Chicago School, as represented in *The City*, that are not listed here. Finding them and identifying what is right or wrong about them is one of the tasks at hand, rather than excoriating the book's contributors for not accurately foreseeing some distant future.

The most enduring of the Chicago School models was the zonal or concentric ring theory, an account of the evolution of differentiated urban social areas by E. W. Burgess. Based on assumptions that included a uniform land surface, universal access to a single-centered city, free competition for space, and the notion that development would take place outward from a central core, Burgess concluded that the city would tend to form a series of concentric zones. The main ecological metaphors invoked to describe this dynamic were invasion, succession, and segregation, by which populations gradually filtered outward from the center as their status and level of assimilation

progressed. The model was predicated on continuing high levels of immigration to the city.

At the core of Burgess' schema was the Central Business District (CBD), which was surrounded by a transitional zone, where older private houses were being converted to offices and light industry, or subdivided to form smaller dwelling units. This was the principal area to which new immigrants were attracted and it included areas of vice and unstable or mobile social groups. The transitional zone was succeeded by a zone of working-men's homes, which included some of the city's oldest residential buildings inhabited by stable social groups. Beyond this, newer and larger dwellings were to be found, occupied by the middle classes. Finally, the commuters' zone was separate from the continuous built-up area of the city, where much of the zone's population was employed. Burgess' model was a broad generalization, and not intended to be taken too literally. He anticipated, for instance, that his schema would apply only in the absence of "opposing factors" such as local topography (in the case of Chicago, Lake Michigan). He also anticipated considerable internal variation within the different zones.

Other urbanists subsequently noted the tendency for cities to grow in star-shaped rather than concentric form, along highways that radiate from a center with contrasting land uses in the interstices. This observation gave rise to a sector theory of urban structure, an idea advanced in the late 1930s by Homer Hoyt (1933, 1939), who observed that once variations arose in land uses near the city center, they tended to persist as the city expanded. Distinctive sectors thus grew out from the CBD, often organized along major highways. Hoyt emphasized that "nonrational" factors could alter urban form, as when skillful promotion influenced the direction of speculative development. He also understood that older buildings could still reflect a concentric ring structure, and that sectors may not be internally homogeneous at one point in time.

The complexities of real-world urbanism were further taken up in the multiple nuclei theory of Chauncey Harris and Edward Ullman (1945). They proposed that cities have a cellular structure in which land uses develop around multiple growth-nuclei within the metropolis as a consequence of accessibility-induced variations in the land-rent surface and agglomeration (dis)economics. Harris and Ullman also allowed that real-world urban structure is determined by broader social and economic forces, the influence of history, and international influences. But whatever the precise reasons for their origin, once nuclei have been established, general growth forces reinforce their preexisting patterns.

Much of the urban research agenda of the 20th century has been predicated on the precepts of the concentric zone, sector, and multiple nuclei theories of urban structure. Their influences can be seen directly in factorial ecologies of intra-urban structure, land-rent models, studies of urban economies and diseconomies of scale, and designs for ideal cities and neighborhoods. The specific and persistent popularity of the Chicago concentric ring model is harder to explain, however, given the proliferation of evidence in support of alternative theories. The most likely reasons for its endurance are related to its beguiling simplicity and the enormous volume of publications produced by adherents of the Chicago School . . .

In the final chapter of *The City*, Louis Wirth (1925) provided a magisterial review of the field of urban sociology, titled (with deceptive simplicity, and astonishing self-effacement) "A Bibliography of the Urban Community." But what Wirth did in this chapter, in a remarkably prescient way, was to summarize the fundamental premises of the Chicago School, and to isolate two fundamental features of the urban condition that were to rise to prominence at the beginning of the 21st century. Specifically, Wirth established that the city lies at the center of, and provides the organizational logic for, a complex regional hinterland based on trade:

Far from being an arbitrary clustering of people and buildings, the city is the nucleus of a wider zone of activity from which it draws its resources and over which it exerts its influence. The city and its hinterland represent two phases of the same mechanism which may be analyzed from various points of view . . .

He also noted that the development of satellite cities is characteristic of the latest phases of city growth,

and that the location of such satellites can exert a determining influence upon the direction of growth:

One of the latest phases of city growth is the development of satellite cities. These are generally industrial units growing up outside of the boundaries of the administrative city, which, however, are dependent upon the city proper for their existence. Often they become incorporated into the city proper after the city has inundated them, and thus lose their identity. The location of such satellites may exert a determining influence upon the direction of the city's growth. These satellites become culturally a part of the city long before they are actually incorporated into it . . .

Wirth further ~~observed that modern communications have transformed the world into a single mechanism, where the global and the local intersect decisively and continuously:~~

With the advent of modern methods of communication the whole world has been transformed into a single mechanism of which a country or a city is merely an integral part. The specialization of function, which has been a concomitant of city growth, has created a state of interdependence of world-wide proportions. Fluctuations in the price of wheat on the Chicago Grain Exchange reverberate to the remotest part of the globe, and a new invention anywhere will soon have to be reckoned with at points far from its origin. The city has become a highly sensitive unit in this complex mechanism, and in turn acts as a transmitter of such stimulation as it receives to a local area. This is a true of economic and political as it is of social and intellectual life. . . .

And there, in a sense, you have it. From a few, relatively humble first steps, we gaze out over the abyss – the yawning gap of an intellectual fault line separating Chicago from Los Angeles. In a few short paragraphs, Wirth anticipated the pivotal moments that characterize Chicago-style urbanism – those primitives that eventually will separate it from an LA-style urbanism. He effectively foreshadowed *avant la lettre* the shift from what I term a "modern" to a "postmodern" city, and, in so doing, the necessity of the transition from the Chicago to the LA School. For it is no longer the center that organizes the urban hinterlands, but the hinterlands that determine what remains of the center.

~~The imperatives of fragmentation have become the principal dynamic in contemporary cities; the 21st century's emerging world cities (including LA) are ground-zero loci in a communications-driven globalizing political economy.~~

The shift toward an LA School may be regarded as a move away from modernist perspectives on the city (à la Chicago School) to a postmodern view of urban process. We are all by now aware that the tenets of modernist thought have been undermined, discredited; in their place, a multiplicity of new ways of knowing have been substituted. Analogously, in postmodern cities, the logics of previous urbanisms have evaporated; and, in the absence of a single new imperative, multiple (ir)rationalities clamor to fill the vacuum. The LA School is distinguishable from the Chicago precepts (as noted above) by the following counterpropositions:

- Traditional concepts of urban form imagine the city organized around a central core; in a revised theory, the urban peripheries are organizing what remains of the center.
- A global, corporate-dominated connectivity is balancing, even offsetting, individual-centered agency in urban processes.
- A linear evolutionist urban paradigm has been usurped by a nonlinear, chaotic process that includes pathological forms such as common-interest developments (CIDs), and life-threatening environmental degradation (e.g. global warming).

In empirical terms, the urban dynamics driving these tendencies are by now well known. They include: *World City*: the emergence of a relatively few centers of command and control in a globalizing economy; *Dual City*: an increasing social polarization, i.e., the increasing gap between rich and poor, between nations, between the powerful and the powerless, between different ethnic, racial, and religious groupings, and between genders; *Hybrid City*: the ubiquity of fragmentation both in material and cognitive life, including the collapse of conventional communities, and the rise of new cultural categories and spaces, including especially cultural hybrids; and *Cybercity*: the challenges of the information age, especially the seemingly ubiquitous capacity of connectivity to supplant the constraints of place.

"Keno capitalism" is the synoptic term that Steven Flusty and I have adopted to describe the spatial

manifestations that are consequent upon the (post-modern) urban condition implied by these assumptions. Urbanization is occurring on a quasi-random field of opportunities in which each space is (in principle) equally available through its connection with the information superhighway. . . . Capital touches down as if by chance on a parcel of land, ignoring the opportunities on intervening lots, thus sparking the development process. The relationship between development of one parcel and nondevelopment of another is a disjointed, seemingly unrelated affair. While not truly a random process, it is evident that the traditional, center-driven agglomeration economies that have guided urban development in the past no longer generally apply. Conventional city form, Chicago-style, is sacrificed in favor of a noncontiguous collage of parcelized, consumption-oriented landscapes devoid of conventional centers yet wired into electronic propinquity and nominally unified by the mythologies of the (dis)information superhighway. In such landscapes, "city centers" become almost an externality of fragmented urbanism; they are frequently grafted onto the landscape as a (much later) afterthought by developers and politicians concerned with identity and tradition. Conventions of "suburbanization" are also redundant in an urban process that bears no relationship to a core-related decentralization.

I am insisting on the term "postmodern" as a vehicle for examining LA urbanism for a number of reasons, even though many protagonists in the debates surrounding the LA School have explicitly distanced themselves from the precepts of postmodernism. I have long understood postmodernism as a concept that embraces three principal referents:

- A series of distinctive cultural and stylistic practices that are in and of themselves intrinsically interesting;
- The totality of such practices, viewed as a cultural ensemble characteristic of the contemporary epoch of capitalism (often referred to as postmodernity); and
- A set philosophical and methodological discourses antagonistic to the precepts of Enlightenment thought, most particularly the hegemony of any single intellectual persuasion.

Implicit in each of these approaches is the notion of a "radical break," i.e., a discontinuity between past and present political, sociocultural and economic

trends. My working hypothesis is that there is sufficient evidence to support the notion that we are witnessing a radical break in each of these three categories. This is the fundamental promise of the revolution prefigured by the LA School; this is why it is so revolutionary in its recapitulation of urban theory.

The localization (sometimes literally the concretization) of these diverse dynamics is creating the emerging time-space fabric of a postmodern society. This is not to suggest that existing (modernist) rationalities have been obliterated from the urban landscape or from our mind-sets; on the contrary, they persist as palimpsests of earlier logics, and continue to influence the emerging spaces of postmodernity. For instance, they are presently serving to consolidate the power of existing place-based centers of communication technologies, even as such technologies are supposed to liberate development from the constraints of place. However, newer urban places, such as LA, are being created by different intentionalities, just as older places such as Chicago are being overlain by the altered intentionalities of postmodernity. Nor am I suggesting that earlier theoretical logics have been (or should be) entirely usurped. For instance, in his revision of the Chicago School, Andrew Abbott ... claimed that the "variables paradigm" of quantitative sociology has been exhausted, and that the "cornerstone of the Chicago vision was location" – points of departure that I regard as totally consistent with the time-space obsessions of the LA School of postmodern urbanism. Another example of overlap between modern and postmodern in current urban

sociology is Michael Peter Smith's evocation of a transnational urbanism ...

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